

THEATRE FESTIVAL

Caught in the Act

Asia's largest drama festival, Theatre Utsav's 11th edition, is being held now, rightly inaugurated by the 96-year-old actor Zohra Segal. That it's an intellectually stimulating and politically vibrant event is proven as there are plays like *The Painted World* from the Czech Republic with no spoken words but a powerful visual language, *Letters of Sufferings* in Afghanistan's Dari dialect and an Indian text *Jimne Lahore Nahin Vekhya* done by two Pakistani directors (S. Kermani and A. Zafari), in Punjabi. Host institute National School of Drama's (NSD) screening committee approved 60 plays, including 12 foreign productions, out of 400, to mount at seven different stages at Mandi House, Delhi, between January 7 and 19. Moreover, 10 young directors have been invited, including Zuleikha Chaudhary, daughter of NSD's

chairperson Amal Allana. The festival showcases 10 renowned contemporary directors like Ram Gopal Bajaj, Prasanna, Rudraprasad Sengupta, Mohan Maharshi and Shyamanand Jalan. There will be 64 productions in total. It will be interesting to see Israel's *Days of Adel*, which talks about the schizophrenia brought on by a divided world. While Gauri Ramnarayanan's *Waterlilies* takes us back to 9/11, Nepal's production *Mayaderi Ke Sapne* deals with the losses in war. Eternal love stories like Laila Majnoo and Heer Ranjha (*Ishq Su Jag Da Moolh*) are presented in modern visual text and contemporary aesthetics in contrast. This time the satellite city for this festival is Lucknow, for a total of 18 plays, including six from abroad, which will travel there from January 11 to 18.

by Sheekesh Mishra



SUNANDA SHARMA

MUSIC FESTIVAL

Notes to be NOTED

The Valley is alive. Not only has it got a new chief minister but it also has a two-week long classical, Sufi and folk music festival in Jammu. Conceived by Santoor player Abhay Rustum Sopori, it focuses on the musical traditions of J&K. "We want to showcase the Sufi traditions, which hold a deep meaning in today's troubled times," says founder of the SaMaPa Academy Pandit Bhajan Sopori. The artistes include Abhay Rustum Sopori, Varsha Aggarwal (santoor), Zunain Halim Khan, Saeed Zafar (sitar), Ragini Rainu (Sufi Vocal), Ustad Iqbal Khan, Vidushi Uma Garg, Sunanda Sharma (Vocal), Radhe Shyam Tiwari (Violin) and Gulzar Ganai (Kashmiri folk). It also includes workshops and demonstrations on various aspects of music. The festival will be held at various cultural centres, auditoriums and educational institutes. On till January 22.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

